

Monkeys and apes

Like humans, monkeys and apes are primates. They use their hands as we do, placing their thumbs against their fingers to grasp things. Monkeys and apes have good vision and large brains for their size. A tail helps to identify which animals are which: most monkeys have tails, apes do not.

MOVING AROUND

Some apes, such as gorillas, spend a lot of time on the ground, while others are skilled climbers and leapers. Monkeys scamper and run on all fours, using their tails for balance or as a fifth limb.



ON TWO FEET
Apes are able to walk on their hindlimbs for short periods of time.



ON FOUR FEET
Monkeys move on all fours, and their limbs are of roughly equal length.



KNUCKLE-WALK
Gorillas and chimpanzees put their weight on the knuckles of their forelimbs.



SWINGING
Some apes use their long arms to swing from branch to branch.

TOOL USE

Apes are intelligent and can make and use tools. Chimpanzees have been observed using rocks to crack nuts, and making "sponges" from leaves and moss to collect water. They also push sticks into termite mounds and trees to "fish" for insects.



GROUP BEHAVIOUR

Most apes and monkeys live in groups, which helps keep them safe from predators. They communicate with each other by using body language and sounds. Chimpanzees even work together to hunt and then share the food among the group.



CARE OF YOUNG

Monkeys and apes have one to two infants at a time, and may devote years to rearing their offspring.



SOCIAL LIFE

Grooming is important not only for cleaning fur, but also for bonding between group members.

MONKEYS

New World monkeys live in South and Central American rainforests. They have fairly broad noses with nostrils that open sideways. Many have gripping tails. Old World monkeys live in Asia and Africa. They have narrower noses than New World monkeys and downward-pointing nostrils. Most are tree-dwellers, although baboons live mainly on the ground.



COMMON SQUIRREL MONKEY



GOLDEN LION TAMARIN



COTTON-TOP TAMARIN



WEEPER CAPUCHIN



NORTHERN NIGHT MONKEY



COMMON MARMOSET



PYGMY MARMOSET



RED HOWLER MONKEY



GREY WOOLLY MONKEY



PIG-TAILED MACAQUE



BARBARY MACAQUE

APES

Found in Africa and Southeast Asia, apes have a more upright body posture than monkeys and do not have a tail. Gorillas, chimpanzees, orangutans, and humans are all "great apes", while gibbons are "lesser apes".



BORNEAN ORANGUTAN